points higher than the 10.5 per cent nominal growth projected for the country in the budget this year. The past nine years have seen Telangana's per capita income grow from Rs 1.12 lakh in 2013-2014 to Rs 3.12 lakh in 2022-23, the highest for any big state. KCR can rightly claim credit for these impressive figures that could enhance his chances for a third term. He has put a strong mechanism in place for his party to publicise his achievements both on the development and welfare front.

KCR VS KCR

That said, 2023 will be tougher for KCR than the past two elections. In 2014, it was the spirit of the new state that made KCR's election a natural one. In 2018, it was the success of Rythu Bandhu that catapulted him back into the seat. This time, both the Congress and BJP have turned on the heat on corruption and *parivarvaad*, as well as leakage of question papers for public recruitment exams. "This election is all about KCR vs KCR," says a Congress strategist. "KCR's second term is marked by serious anti-Opposition strategies and undermining civil society organisations visibly," says Vageeshan. "His know-all attitude is a hurdle that hinders the process of governance."

IN 2014, KCR RODE ON THE SPIRIT OF A NEW STATE. IN 2018, IT WAS RYTHU BANDHU. 2023 WILL BE TOUGHER AS RIVAL PARTIES TURN ON THE HEAT ON CORRUPTION AND *PARIVARVAAD*

Indeed, one common grouse against KCR is that he is opinionated and does not listen to anyone, not even his son KTR. His administration, too, is considered to be too centralised, though KCR says it's only because it makes the task of administration easier. That aside, profligacy and populism have stressed state finances and increased the debt burden, trends that can only be unhealthy for growth in the long term. The state had total liabilities of Rs 3.2 lakh crore (28 per cent of the GSDP), according to the Comptroller and Auditor General of India's audited figures for 2021-22. This is well above the 20 per cent norm laid down for states under the Fiscal Responsibility and Budget Management (FRBM) Act, 2003. Defending the state's debt position, KTR says that Telangana's investments are in critical infrastructure areas such as power, irrigation, education and health. "They have a positive impact on the quality of life, disease prevention and economic relief," he says, comparing Telangana's current debt to GDP ratio of 25 per cent to India's 60 per cent.

Another issue that has turned vexatious for the BRS is the sinking of some of the piers of the Medigadda barrage of the Rs 80,000 crore Kaleshwaram Lift Irrigation Scheme (KLIS) in October. Both the Congress and BJP contend that KLIS has been a cash cow for the BRS first family. Though the National Dam Safety Authority (NDSA) has pointed to flaws, the ruling party has dismissed its findings as politically orchestrated.

Criticism has flowed in for his welfare schemes as well. Among them is the 2BHK Housing scheme for the poor. Figures show that of the 292,000 houses sanctioned, only 180,000 have been completed so far. "The tardy implementation of some welfare schemes, the functioning of the state-run power distribution utilities, the greater concentration on development in and around Hyderabad and the lack of a market for the bumper paddy production have left rural voters disillusioned," says E. Venkatesu of the University of Hyderabad.

Youth are another section whose disaffection can cost the party dear. Those under 35 years of age can influence poll results significantly and in Telangana this cohort comprises over 30 per cent of its nearly 30 million-strong electorate. Of these, some 800,000 are in the 18-19 age group while another 7.5 million are in the 19-35 age bracket. KCR claims he has brought down the unemployment rate in Telangana considerably, but jobs for youth remains a hot-button issue in the state. Hoping to cash in on it, the Congress specifically highlights issues pertaining to unemployment, even attributing suicides to the failure to fill job vacancies and the non-implementation of the 2018 pre-poll promise of an unemployment dole of Rs 3,016 a month.

However, even with the tornado swirling around him, KCR himself appears calm and composed, much like the eye of the storm. There is no doubt in his mind that he will be back for a third time. After a hard day of campaigning, he relaxes at his farmhouse, on the outskirts of Hyderabad. At night, he reads a biography of Deng Xiaoping, once China's paramount leader who was instrumental in making his country an economic superpower. KCR has his sights set on a national role in the future. Win the state that he founded for a third time, and the road to that future will no doubt become that much smoother. ■